

OS is huge. Gnome, on the other hand, is direct in its approach and does not offer any eye candy. Nevertheless, it is functional and is less demanding on system resources.

Ubuntu, as we mentioned earlier, defaults to Gnome and presents a clean desktop interface. Despite the single CD installation that takes only 25 minutes to install, a clean install of Ubuntu provides enough applications to get your work done. It comes with Firefox 1.0 for Internet browsing, OpenOffice 1.1 and Evolution for communications and Gimp is included as the default image manipulator.

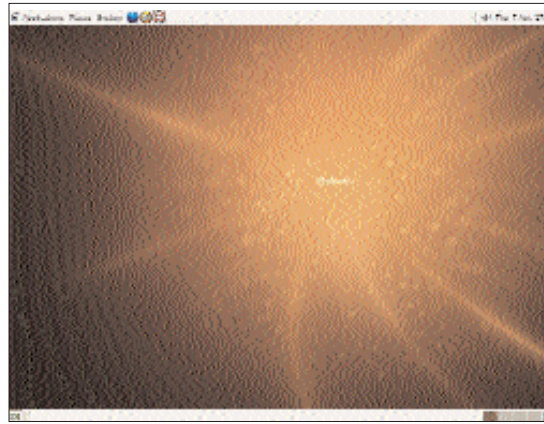
On the multimedia side, it includes Totem movie player, Rhythmbox media player, Sound Juicer CD ripper and a volume monitor. A Bittorrent client is also included along with Gaim and Xchat IRC.

Being based on Debian, Ubuntu uses its excellent apt-get package system for updating and installing new applications. If you don't plan to fiddle around in the command line, Ubuntu also includes Synaptic package manager, a front-end tool for apt, which makes installing applications a breeze. By default, the apt repositories are not enabled, and you need to uncomment the lines in the /etc/apt/sources.list file.

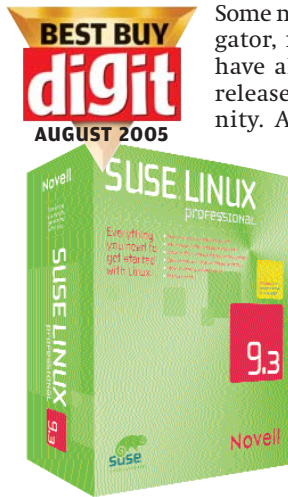
Debian repositories have a huge collection of applications and you can be sure of finding what you want.

Fedora Core 4 and RedHat offer you a choice of using either KDE or Gnome—we preferred the KDE version. Both come on four CD-ROMs and hence, during installation, if you choose to install all packages, it takes around two-and-a-half hours. With that many applications installed, you will never have to hunt for more!

To give you an idea, the menu will reveal 30 apps in the accessories section, 11 games, 16 graphics related software, 19 Internet related software... the list goes on.



An iconless desktop from Ubuntu enhances appeal without compromising on functionality



Some nifty tools such as the Akregator, for collecting news feeds, have also made it to this latest release from the Fedora community. A new tool called Yum is also included for easy system update and get the latest patches.

OpenLx is also based on the Fedora core, but has some good features bundled with the OS. An evaluation version of Kalkulate, a financial accounting application is provided with the OS. This distro also bundles dozens of development kits such as Mono development, Eclipse, etc., an

audio visual editor such as hydrogen, and Blender, a 3D modelling suite. The Clamav anti-virus software is also offered in the pack. Overall, we found the list of packages to be more than enough for anyone to use.

SuSe and Mandrake have always believed in offering the best possible collection of applications along with their OS. SuSe 9.3 professional does not disappoint on that count. Just to check, we decided to install all the applications provided in the SuSe DVD, and it took about three hours to install! It would be safe to say that they are more than enough applications available for a life-time!

We found SuSe to be up-to-date as far as applications are concerned. It had KDE 3.4 and Gnome 2.10. OpenOffice version 2.0 also made it into this distro, and we were glad that we wouldn't miss the 'format painter' feature that was missing in the previous versions of OpenOffice. Though the splash screen says OpenOffice 2.0,

in reality, it is 1.9.X.X—a stable version of 2.0 is still awaited.

Beagle, a desktop searching utility and XEN, a virtualisation tool for the Linux operating system are some of the highlights of SuSe 9.3 professional, and should please true power users. Beagle is switched off by default and you need to create an empty .runbeagle file from Gnome to make it work.

We plugged in a flash drive into each of these distros to see the reaction and to our disbelief, it was auto-mounted and a temporary desktop icon was created, through which you could access the data. Our similar attempt with a digital camera, however, did not work. We tried setting up a network printer, and in most cases, the result was failure. A lot of work still needs to be done on all these distros.

Conclusion

To compare Ubuntu with either SuSe or Redhat would be unjust. So, we further classified this category into free-to-use and paid distros.

Ubuntu and Fedora fall under the free to use category, and both are projects driven by the community. When it comes to the number of applications that are bundled with them, Fedora seems to be your best bet. Ubuntu, on the other hand, provides what's necessary and you can upgrade your system as per your needs later on.

Ubuntu is doing well right now, and its success will depend entirely on the efforts of this community. From our limited experience with the community we can say they are quite active and you can expect a quick response to your queries. We bet our money on Ubuntu.

So we are left with RedHat WS, OpenLx SuSe 9.3 professional and Mandrake 10.1 as paid distros. Here, the verdict is clear—SuSe wipes the floor with the competition and wins, thanks to the truck loads of software bundled, cutting-edge features such as XEN, beagle and up-to-date software. However, this, under no circumstances undermines the efforts made by OpenLx and RedHat to offer well-rounded Linux solutions.

Moreover, since you will be coughing up cash, having a support system in place gives peace of mind and SuSe has a good presence in India via Novell, which unfortunately, can't be said about Mandrake. ☒

sanket_naik@thinkdigit.com

Contact Sheet: Linux Distributions		
Distro	Web site	Contact information
Linspire 5.0 CNR Edition	www.linspire.com	
Xandros Desktop OS 3	www.xandros.com	G.T.Enterprises
RedHat WS	www.redhat.com	Tel No: +91-80-2669
Mandrake 10.1 Power Pack +	www.mandrake.com	5890/91/92/ 93/94
OpenLx 11.0	www.openlx.com	Fax : +91-80-2669 5887
SuSe 9.3 Professional	www.suse.com	
Ubuntu	www.ubuntulinux.com	Download from Web site
Fedora	http://fedora.redhat.com	With Digit DVD this month